

Little Buck and Little Bull Loaders: Handling Guide

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First thing to clear up: we build both

Little Bull is not a competitor of Little Buck. We build both. We are **Little Buck Loader, LLC** of Sycamore, Illinois, a family shop that has been making aftermarket front-end loaders for John Deere and Kubota garden tractors since 2015.

The Little Buck is our entry model. The Little Bull is our heavy-lift model. So if you bought a Little Bull, everything on our website and our YouTube channel is your documentation too. You are just looking at the bigger brother.

- Website: <https://www.littlebuckloader.com>
- YouTube: <https://www.youtube.com/@LittleBuckLoader>
- Phone: (815) 345-3940
- Email: hello@littlebuckloader.com
- Factory / pickup: 358 North California Street, Sycamore, IL 60178

The operator's manual that shipped with your machine is the authority. This guide gathers what we cover across our videos, FAQ and blog into one place, so you do not have to go hunting. If the manual and this guide disagree, follow the manual.

Which one do you have?

The fastest way to tell them apart is to look at how the loader holds onto the tractor.

	Little Buck	Little Bull
How it mounts	Channel in the loader base drops onto the tractor's front weight bracket, held by two spring-loaded pins	Heavy-duty mid-mount brackets bolted to the tractor frame, plus support arms and turnbuckles
Lift capacity	340 lbs	440 lbs
Breakout force	450 lbs	550 lbs
Max lift height	5' 9"	5' 9"
Bucket	48 to 48.5 in wide, 4 cu ft	48 to 48.5 in wide, 4 cu ft
Dig depth	2 in below grade	2 in below grade
Weight	around 250 lbs	350 to 450 lbs
Mounting jack	no	yes, detachable, on rollers
Works with a cab	yes, hard or soft	no
Price (2026)	from \$2,490	from \$3,490

Little Buck	Little Bull
	

We also build the **Little Bull QuikMount / QuikSystem**, which is the Little Bull with a tool-free quick-attach plate on the end of the arms so you can swap bucket, forks, grapple and snow pusher without pulling the whole loader off. And the **Z Buck** for zero-turn mowers and UTVs.

The Z Buck	Demo video (click)
	

The Z Buck mounts to a zero-turn mower or a UTV rather than a garden tractor.

Before the first attach

Do these once, when the loader comes off the pallet. Skipping them is how people end up with a squeaky, sloppy loader and a tipped tractor.

1. Grease it. It ships dry on purpose. We do not pre-grease, because grease traps cardboard dust in shipping. Give every zerk **two pumps** before the first use. We use and recommend Valvoline Multi-Purpose Grease (VV614). After that, re-grease every **10 to 15 hours** of work. Takes under two minutes.

2. Hang ballast on the back. This is the single most important safety item. A loaded bucket pushes weight forward, the rear tires go light, and you lose both traction and steering. We sell two options:

- **DIY weight basket:** fill with pavers, concrete blocks or a bucket of anything heavy. Cheap and adjustable.
- **Weight bar:** takes six 42 lb suitcase weights, up to 252 lbs total. Tidier and quicker to fit.

Both bolt on using the existing hitch pan bolts. They fit the X700 series, X465 to X495, X575 to X595, and the 300 series.

3. Air up the tires. Run roughly **10 PSI above** the sidewall recommendation while the loader is on.

4. Check the hydraulic fluid. We ship loaders wet with Blaine's Farm & Fleet Tractor Trans-Hydraulic Fluid, which meets John Deere JDM J20C. Mixing it with Type F ATF is fine. If you want to run Type F only, you will need about 1.5 extra quarts in the system.

The three valves, and the one upgrade worth doing

Three valves come up whenever someone puts a loader on an X700. They do different jobs and people mix them up constantly, so here is each one in plain language, then what to actually buy.

Pressure relief valve

The "it is too heavy, let go" safety. When the tractor is pushing or pulling so hard that something inside could break, this valve lets the muscles relax by bleeding off a little oil so nothing snaps.

Cutoff valve

An on/off gate for the oil. Closed, oil cannot go a certain way, so some tools or parts of the tractor do not move. Open, oil flows and the loader or mower works better and faster. Some owners swap this valve so the gate works in a way that makes implements respond more crisply.

Flow control valve

A speed knob for the oil. It decides how fast oil goes to each part. Without one, the mower deck and the loader fight each other for oil and one of them ends up slow. Raising the deck all the way stops it stealing oil, so the loader runs smoother.

To find out whether you have one, look for a small knob or lever labeled something like "rate of drop" or "implement lift speed". That is your flow control.

What an X758 already has

The X758 uses a hydrostatic transaxle in the Tuff Torq K90 family, which does have internal free-wheeling valves from the factory. The specific hydrostatic **pressure relief** valve for loader use is usually an upgrade, not standard equipment.

We are direct about this: the existing forward free-wheeling valve must be replaced by a transaxle hydrostatic pressure relief valve to protect the transmission when running a loader or driving hard.

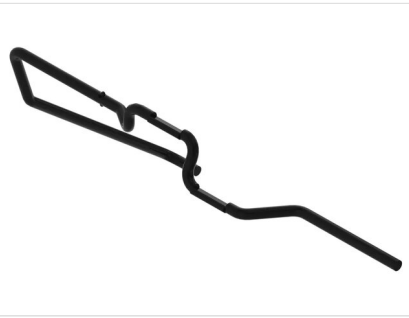
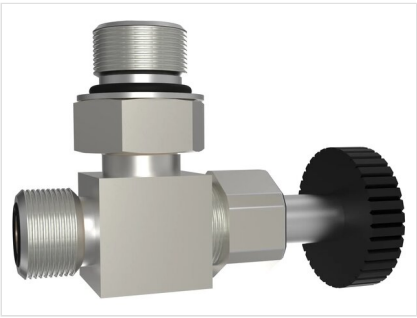
For the **cutoff valve**, the tractor has factory hydraulic valves for implements, including a kind of cutoff function in the circuit. Some owners replace the factory one for better loader performance. Optional, not required.

For **flow control**, some X700s come with an implement lift flow control valve and some do not. If yours does not, either buy the Deere part (AM134625) or just raise the deck to maximum when running the loader, which achieves much the same thing for free.

What to buy

The three parts, at dealer prices quoted for an X758 in 2026:

Part	Number	Price	Verdict
Pressure relief valve, transaxle	MIA885144	\$465.71	Strongly recommended
Neutral control rod	M146148	\$50.73	Buy with the valve above
Flow control valve	AM134625	\$283.36	Optional

Pressure relief valve	Neutral control rod	Flow control valve
		
MIA885144	M146148	AM134625

The relief valve photo is a dealer shot of this valve family. The 2WD and 4WD versions look identical and differ only by the stamp, so go by the stamp rather than the picture.

1. Transaxle hydrostatic pressure relief valve, MIA885144. Strongly recommended.

This is the one upgrade genuinely worth doing if you run a loader. Picture it: you are in 4WD, pushing into a pile, engine revved and the forward pedal down. The wheels cannot spin because traction is good or you have hit a stump. Pressure builds in the hydrostatic system with nowhere to go. The relief valve opens at a safe pressure and dumps the excess, so an expensive transaxle does not get hammered.

Our rule: if you push the tractor hard, replace it. If you are gentle and avoid dead stalls, it is optional. Running a front loader counts as pushing it hard.

MIA885144 is the current Deere number. It supersedes AM122228, and it is the one to order today. Deere lists it as fitting X728, X729, X738, X748, X749, X758 and X948, which is the 4WD and all-wheel-steer side of the range. Older references, including our own install guide, still use the previous numbers:

Drivetrain	Older number	Stamped	Current Deere part
2WD machines	BM15043 (AM121248)	"2WD"	ask the dealer
4WD, incl. X758	BM15044 (AM122228), sold as BW15044	"4WD"	MIA885144

Whichever number is on the box, check for the **4WD stamp on the valve itself**.

It installs in place of the forward free-wheeling valve. The job means pulling the seat and fender deck to reach the fuel tank, then swapping both the old free-wheeling valve and its control lever. One caution that matters: **clean the transaxle before removing the valve**, or you will drop dirt straight into the hydraulic system.

2. Neutral control rod, M146148. Buy it with the valve.

This is the free-wheeling valve control lever, and it is why our install guide is titled for the lever as well as the valve. The new relief valve is physically bigger than the free-wheeling valve it replaces, so the standard lever no longer clears it. The M146148 rod is bent to fit around the larger valve. Order it at the same time or the install stops halfway.

- [Our install guide](#)
- Video walkthrough, all X700 models with K9X axles:



3. Flow control valve, AM134625. Optional.

Deere also lists this one as a hydraulic cylinder lockout valve, which describes what it does better than "flow control" does. It goes in the line feeding the rockshaft, the circuit that raises the mower deck and the 3-point. It has a black knurled knob you turn by hand.

Close it and oil stops going to the rockshaft first and goes straight to the front outlets instead, so the loader responds instantly rather than waiting for the deck cylinder to reach the end of its travel. Open it and the deck and 3-point work normally again.

Check this one on your own machine before you rely on it. Deere's description is that closing the valve disables the deck hydraulics and speeds up the loader, which means **closed for loader work, open for mowing**. Some parts sheets say the opposite. It is also a diverter rather than a hard stop: owners report that with a deck or a rear implement mounted, things still creep up and down slowly, and that around 5 or a quarter turn past 5 on the dial is where the deck stops drifting. Turn the knob and watch what actually moves.

If you would rather not spend the \$283, the free version of this fix is to run the mower deck at its highest position whenever the loader is on. That is the same advice we give, and it costs nothing.

4. Updated cutoff valve. Optional, and no part number yet.

Separate from the above. Some of our customers have reported improved implement performance by replacing the factory cutoff valve. It is not required, but it may make loader operation more efficient. We have not published a part number. Run the stock valve. If it feels sluggish, call your Deere dealer with the serial number, mention this guidance, and have them cross-reference the updated valve for the X758 hydraulic circuit.

Attaching the Little Buck

Four steps, and the whole thing takes a couple of minutes once you have done it twice.

1. **Close the loader.** Curl the bucket back and bring the arms down so the loader sits in its closed position. Any other position makes the alignment fight you.
2. **Set it on the tractor.** Lift by the **middle beam** and lower the loader onto the landing bar and the attachment points at the front of the tractor. The attachment points sit low at the front, parallel to the wheels, with the landing bar directly above them.
3. **Lock the pins.** Push in and twist the two spring-loaded pins, one on each side, until they seat and lock.
4. **Connect the hoses.** Match the color-coded loader hoses to the matching tractor outlets. See the color map below.

Watch this one first	Older walkthrough
	

Both pictures are links: [Attaching and Detaching Your Little Buck Loader](#) and the older [How to attach your Little Buck Loader](#).

Your tractor needs **four quick-connect hydraulic outlets**, that is two dual ports, for full loader function. Machines with only two outlets need a converter kit, and that costs you power steering capability.

Attaching the Little Bull

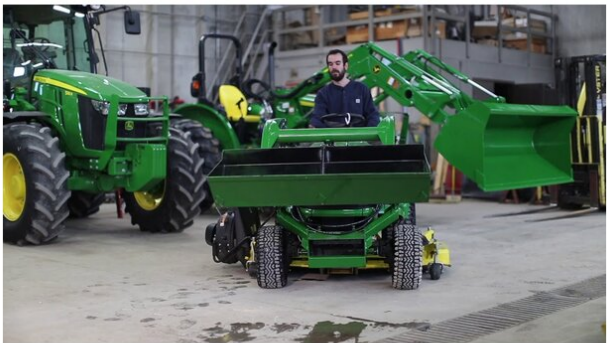
The Bull is heavier and mounts to the frame rather than to the weight bracket, so there is more to it. Use the rolling jack that came with the loader. Do not try to muscle 400 lbs into alignment.

This is the order we use in our current video. Two things in it surprise people: **the hoses go on early**, before the loader is mounted, because you need the tractor's hydraulics to work the jack; and the spring-loaded pins come out **after** the jack is off, not before.

1. **Swap the motor mount brackets.** Pop the hood and remove the two motor mount brackets on each side. Fit the brackets that came with the loader in their place.
2. **Get the loader off the pallet.** Take off the ratchet strap, unscrew the three screws in the bucket, and tip the loader back toward the tractor.
3. **Plug in the color-coded hoses.** See the [hose color map](#).
4. **Lower onto the jack.** Start the tractor and lower the hydraulics until the jack touches the ground.
5. **Roll it on.** Raise the jack until the top plate clears the weight bar, roll the loader in right above the bar, and pop it on.
6. **Unscrew the jack and take it off**, for maximum clearance.
7. **Free the spring-loaded pins** from their notches, one on each side.
8. **Fit the turnbuckles.** Attach the motor mount bracket turnbuckle on each side and tighten until snug, then **another two turns**.
9. **Restart the tractor** and run the loader through its range to confirm everything works.

Our FAQ says to snug the turnbuckles and add **one** full hand turn, while our current video says **two**. Two is the newer instruction. Either way they loosen with vibration, so see [Troubleshooting](#) for the jam nut fix that stops them backing off for good.

Two short clips cover the early steps in more detail:

Step 1: pop the hood	Step 2: attach the supports
	

Full walkthrough video: [Attaching your Little Bull Loader to your John Deere - Updated!](#)



Running an Antler Grappler too? We have a combined video: [Attaching Your Little Bull Loader and Antler Grappler](#).

Note: the Little Bull does not work with a cab, hard or soft. If you run a cab, the Little Buck is the one that fits.

Hydraulic hose color map

The loader hoses are color-coded and so are the tractor outlets. Match color to color. The catch is that the **X series reverses the layout** compared with the older tractors, so do not go by memory if you have owned both.

300 series, and 425 / 445 / 455:

	Left	Right
Top	yellow	silver
Bottom	black	green

X series:

	Left	Right
Top	black	green
Bottom	yellow	silver

Getting it wrong is not a disaster. Hooking them up backwards on the first try will not damage the tractor or the loader. The lift or tilt simply will not work correctly, which tells you to swap a pair. Full article: [Hydraulic Hose Connections 101](#).

Detaching

Order matters here, mostly because of trapped hydraulic pressure.

1. **Pick your spot.** Somewhere level, dry, and out of the way. The loader will live there until you come back for it.
2. **Set the loader down** so the arms are low and you can reach the spring-loaded pins. On the Little Bull, fit the jack first and let it take the weight. See [The Little Bull's jack](#).
3. **Shut the tractor off.**
4. **Bleed the pressure.** With the engine off, push both the tilt lever and the arm lever **up and down** several times. This is the step people skip, and it is why their hoses will not go back on later.
5. **Disconnect the hoses.**
6. **Pull the pins.** On the Bull, back off the turnbuckles and remove the support arms first.
7. **Back the tractor away**, slowly and straight.

Reverse the attach steps and you have it.

Little Buck, both directions



Little Bull, detaching



The Roll-Off Caster Kit

A pair of wheels for the loader itself. The kit clamps two steel bars with casters onto the bucket, so once the loader is off the tractor it stands on its own and rolls. No lifting, no shuffling 250 lbs of steel across the floor, no fighting the alignment when you put it back on. It also lets you park the loader in a corner of the garage instead of leaving it out in the yard.

\$490, and the box holds three things: two heavy-duty steel caster support bars and one steel arm locking tie. Made in Sycamore.



Two caster bars and the locking tie. That is the whole kit.

This one is for the Buck. We list it as fitting the Little Buck only, on the 4X5 and X-Series tractors. If you run a Bull you do not need it: the Bull comes with its own jack on rollers, covered in [the next section](#).

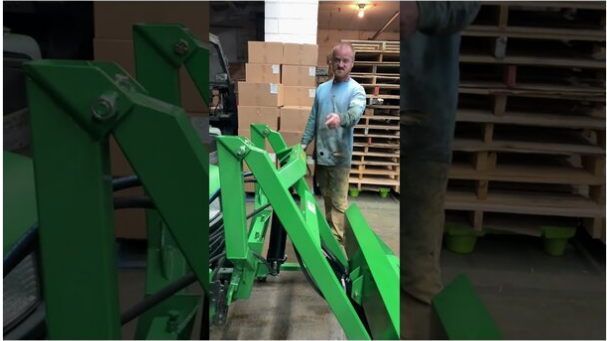
There is a second limitation worth knowing. The kit is for taking the loader off and putting it back on **after** the normal first-time installation. You cannot use it to unbox a new loader and mount it for the very first time.

How it works

1. **Attach the caster bars.** Raise the bucket to a comfortable working height. Clip one end of each steel bar onto the bottom lip of the bucket, between the welds.
2. **Lower to the ground.** Bring the bucket down until the casters are solidly on the floor and the weight has come off the tractor's front end.
3. **Release the mounting pins.** Pull the spring-loaded pins on both sides to free the loader from the tractor mount.

4. **Tilt and lift off.** Use the tilt cylinder to raise the loader frame clear of the mounts. Watch your hose slack here.
5. **Lock the arms.** Fit the steel tie so the bucket is locked to the loader arms and the whole thing stays rigid and upright.
6. **Depressurize and roll away.** Shut the tractor off, work the levers to release line pressure, disconnect the hoses, and push the loader wherever you want it.

Step 6 is the same pressure-bleeding step as in [Detaching](#), and skipping it causes the same trouble with hoses that will not reconnect.

Install the kit	Reattach in minutes
	

The Little Bull's jack

If you run a Little Bull, you do not need the caster kit. The Bull ships with its own detachable screw jack on rollers, and it does the same job: it carries the loader's weight while you mount or dismount, and it is what the loader stands and rolls on once it is off the tractor. That is the whole reason the caster kit is a Buck-only accessory. The Buck has no jack, so we sell it one. The Bull already has the capability in the box.

The jack is a screw jack. You wind it up and down by hand to raise and lower the front of the loader, and it rides on rollers so the loader can be pushed around once its weight is on the jack rather than on the tractor.

Fitting the jack and taking the loader off

The jack goes on before anything gets unpinned, because it has to take the weight first. Nothing here should require lifting.

1. **Fit the jack** to the loader and wind it down until it is close to the floor.
2. **Lower the loader onto it.** With the tractor running, lower the hydraulics until the jack is solidly on the ground and the loader's weight has come off the tractor's front end.
3. **Back the turnbuckles off** and free them from the motor mount brackets on both sides.

4. **Put the spring-loaded pins back** into their notches so the mount releases.
5. **Wind the jack** to lift the top plate clear of the weight bar.
6. **Shut the tractor off and bleed the pressure.** Work the tilt and arm levers up and down with the engine off, then disconnect the hoses. Skip this and the couplers will not go back together later. Same trap as in [Detaching](#).
7. **Back the tractor away** slowly and straight. The loader stays standing on its jack.

Putting it back on is the same sequence in reverse, and it is written out step by step under [Attaching the Little Bull](#). Steps 4 through 6 there are the jack steps.

Moving it around the garage

Once the loader is standing on its own jack with the hoses off, it rolls. Push it by the frame or the arms rather than the bucket, so you are pushing through the structure instead of levering on the bucket pins.

A few things that make this easier:

- **Wind the jack down for rolling, up for parking.** More clearance clears cracks and thresholds. Wound down, the loader sits stable and will not creep on a sloped floor.
- **Rollers want a hard, flat floor.** Sealed concrete is ideal. Gravel and expansion joints will stop small rollers dead, so lay a scrap of plywood over a bad seam rather than forcing it.
- **Watch the balance.** Weight sits high and forward on these loaders. Move slowly, keep the bucket curled down and low, and turn in wide arcs rather than pivoting sharply.
- **Park it where you can drive back to it.** You need a straight approach with the tractor to reattach, so leave clearance in front, not just to the sides.
- **Chock it on any slope.** A wheeled 400 lb loader that starts moving on its own is not something you want to catch by hand.

We have not shot a video devoted to the jack, or a standalone photo of it. It is shown in use in both loader videos below. In the attach video it appears around the steps where the loader is lowered onto it and then unscrewed; in the detach video it is what the loader is left standing on.

Attaching, jack in use	Detaching, jack takes the weight
	

Moving around with it

It is a material mover, not an excavator. Dirt, mulch, gravel, snow, all fine. Prying stumps and digging into hard ground is not what these are built for. You can fit a toothbar (the Piranha is the one we recommend) as long as you are not excavating with it.

Roughly 10 feet of tractor plus loader on the Little Buck, so give yourself room in gates and doorways.

Some practical habits:

- Carry the bucket low while travelling. High and loaded is how garden tractors tip.
- Keep the ballast on whenever the loader is on. Every time.
- Take slopes straight up and down rather than across the face.
- Do not lift people, and do not let anyone stand under a raised bucket.
- Ease into the hydraulics rather than slamming the levers.

Mowing deck. On the 400, 420 and 430 the deck has to come off. On everything else the deck can stay. With the deck on you may need to pause and let the lift cylinder hit the end of its stroke before the tilt responds, and setting the deck to its highest position minimizes that. Optional lockout valves send flow to tilt only when you are not mowing.

Opening the hood with the loader attached. With the arms fully down the hood will not clear. Start the tractor, raise the arms to **half height**, drape a shop rag over the crossbar so you do not scratch the paint, and open the hood. Thirty seconds, and you can reach the dipstick and radiator normally. ([blog post](#))

While attaching, a strip of pipe insulation or a folded towel on the hood edge saves the green paint. We wrote a [whole post on cheap hood protection](#).

Swapping attachments (QuikSystem)

If you have the QuikMount, the front plate is a quick-attach and the tools come off and on without any tools and without removing the loader. The full QuikSystem bundle is QuikMount, QuikBucket (48" utility bucket), QuikForks, QuikGrapple and QuikPush (50" snow pusher). No extra hydraulic circuits needed. Ballast is still mandatory.

QuikMount on the tractor



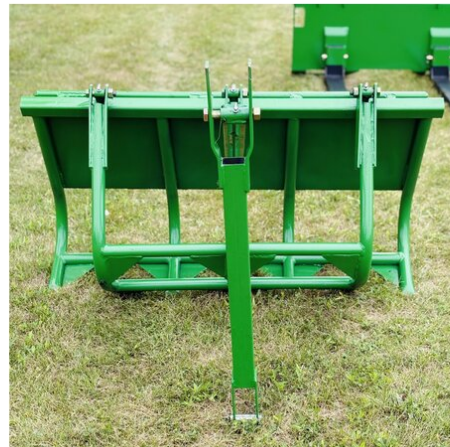
QuikBucket, 48"



QuikForks



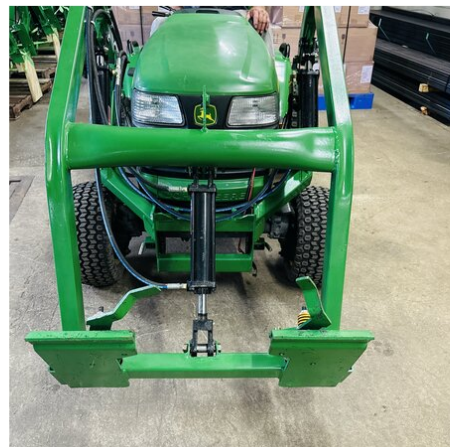
QuikGrapple



QuikPush snow pusher, 50"



Quick-attach plate, head on



The Antler Grapppler is our mechanical grapple, and we are proud of how simple it turned out: it needs no extra hydraulic line at all. It runs off the bucket tilt linkage. Tilt forward and the grapple opens, tilt back and it closes. It fits every Little Buck and Little Bull. The bolt-on plates sit 24" apart center to center, and the spacing is adjustable.



Moving the loader to a different tractor

Most swaps need a **new mounting base and new hoses** cut to length for the new machine. The exceptions and dead ends:

From	To	What it takes
425 / 445 / 455	X series	No kit. Grind about 1/4" off the front weight bar and rotate the cylinders 180 degrees
X series	425 / 445 / 455	Not possible
318-style	X series, 4x5, or 400 / 420 / 430	New mounting base and hoses
400 / 420 / 430	X700 series	New mounting base and hoses

We sell conversion kits on our site. Call us before you buy, since the fit depends on the exact year.

Troubleshooting

The hoses will not reconnect after removal. Almost always trapped pressure in the tilt circuit. Wrap a rag around the male nipple on the tilt hose and press the center pin. Fluid will squirt out, which is why the rag is there. That releases the pressure and the coupler will seat. Bleeding the levers before disconnecting (step 4 of detaching) prevents this in the first place.

Lift or tilt works backwards, or one function does nothing. Hoses are on the wrong ports. Check the color map above, remembering that the X series layout is flipped.

Turnbuckles keep backing off (Little Bull). Normal, caused by vibration on rough ground and by uneven loads. Quick fix: tighten the offending one 1 to 2 extra full turns. Permanent fix: thread a **1/2" coarse-thread nut** onto the right-hand threaded rod and snug it against the body as a jam nut. Costs pennies and ends the problem. ([blog post](#))

Sluggish or weak hydraulics on an X700. Raise the mower deck to its highest position first, since a low deck steals oil from the loader. If that does not settle it, see [The three valves](#): a flow control valve or an updated cutoff valve can help, and if you work the tractor hard the transaxle pressure relief valve is the upgrade to make.

Loader feels sloppy at the mount. It should not wear there. The Buck uses spring-loaded pins in the weight bracket channel, the Bull uses mid-mount brackets that prevent play. If there is slop, check the pins and the turnbuckles before assuming wear. If it still feels loose, call us.

Maintenance at a glance

Interval	Job
Before first use	Two pumps of grease per zerk
Every 10 to 15 hours	Re-grease all fittings
Every use	Walk around, check pins seated, check hose routing
Occasionally	Check turnbuckle tension (Bull), check tire PSI at +10 over sidewall
Seasonally	Check hydraulic fluid level, inspect hoses for chafing

Grease: Valvoline Multi-Purpose (VV614). Hydraulic fluid: JDM J20C spec, Type F ATF compatible.

Video library

All from [our YouTube channel](#) unless noted.

Video	Topic
Attaching and Detaching Your Little Buck Loader	The main Little Buck video, both directions
How to attach your Little Buck Loader	Earlier attach walkthrough
Attaching your Little Bull Loader to your John Deere - Updated!	Current Little Bull procedure
Step 1: Pop the hood and get started	Little Bull, step 1
Step 2: Attaching the supports	Little Bull, step 2
Detaching Your Little Bull Loader	Taking the Bull back off
Roll-Off Caster Kit Install	Fitting the caster kit, short
Reattach in Minutes with the Roll-Off Caster Kit	Putting the loader back on, short
Attaching Your Little Bull Loader and Antler Grappler	Loader plus grapple
Z BUCK Loader for a John Deere Zero Turn	Z Buck
X700 Transaxle Hydraulic Pressure Relief Valve Install	The valve upgrade, all K9X axles, by Josh's Green Garage
Little Bull Review and Un-Palletizing	Unboxing, by Josh's Green Garage

The channel also has videos on the JD Talon, KBX Talon, snow pusher and bucket extender installs, and the QuikSystem conversion kit.

Reference links

- [Setup / installation page](#)
- [FAQ - our deepest single page](#)
- [Little Buck operator's manual \(PDF\)](#)
- [Install the free-wheeling lever and transaxle pressure relief valve - part numbers and procedure](#)
- [Deere parts: M1A885144 pressure relief valve, M146148 neutral rod, AM134625 flow control valve](#)
- [What to know before you buy, X700 series](#)
- [Little Buck product page](#)
- [Little Bull product page](#)
- [Little Bull QuikSystem](#)
- [Roll-Off Caster Kit - \\$490](#)
- [Conversion kits](#)
- [Buck vs Bull vs QuikMount comparison](#)
- [Will a Little Buck fit my John Deere?](#)
- [Why ballast weight matters](#)
- [Greasing guide](#)

There is also an active owners group on Facebook with hundreds of customer videos and photos, and it is worth joining for the odd tractor-specific question.

About the images

Every picture in this guide comes from our own product pages and video thumbnails. They are all local copies, so the guide reads offline, and they are standardized to the same size so they line up evenly on the page.

Written September 2026. Prices and specs were current at that date. Nothing here replaces your operator's manual or a phone call to the factory. We would rather answer the phone than have you guess.